condemned Dyer for using excessive force and for not providing aid to the injured, there were some who lauded the general as ‘the saviour of the Punjab’. A collection was set up for the general in which over £26,000 was raised,[113] and Montagu and Chelmsford were even criticised for their treatment of him. The council of the European Association of India, for example, announced that ‘[the] General body of Europeans in India strongly uphold Dyer and condemn [the] actions of [the] Government of India and Secretary of State’.[114] During a debate in the House of Commons on the Hunter Report, there was a strong reaction among some of the Conservative politicians to Montagu’s speech against Dyer[115] (although one observer believed most of those involved were ‘less Pro-Dyer than anti-Montagu’).[116] The CIGS himself believed that in this time of troubles, the British government should be standing by the actions of its soldiers.[117] Such defence of Dyer, however, was resented by many Indians. As a consequence, at the Indian National Congress of September 1920 it was decided to adopt Gandhi’s resolution for a programme of non-co-operation with the Indian government.[118]

For Chelmsford, the best way of dealing with this action was to largely ignore it. He believed that the Indian public would realise the ‘folly’ of non-co-operation.[119] As one historian has put it, ‘Chelmsford’s slogan was “caution and watchfulness”’.[120] In a letter to the viceroy, Montagu voiced his support: ‘I believe your treatment of Gandhi will be successful...I am quite certain that if you have to move against him, he will hunger-strike and die in prison, and then I don’t know where we should be.’[121] Chelmsford, nevertheless, faced criticism by others in London, who ‘want to know why you don’t lock him [Gandhi] up at once because they disapprove of him’.[122] However, the viceroy and his colleagues were well aware that Bolshevism thrived on popular discontent, and they were not about to provide fodder for Bolshevik propaganda by creating martyrs of Gandhi and his followers.

Potentially more dangerous than the Bolshevik interest in Gandhi and Indian nationalism, however, was Moscow’s involvement in the nationalist and pan-Islamic agitation in Central and southern Asia during 1920. When it came to Islam the Bolshevik regime had to tread carefully, as instructions from Moscow pointed out to its party members in February: ‘Religious prejudices are much stronger among the Mussulmans than among Russians